with vested interests," he said.

The traditional Sena and NCP's "interest in Sangli" is also being seen by the Congress as an attempt to gain ground among voters ahead of the Maharashtra assembly election, also scheduled to be held this year, especially since both parties will be going into the polls with new symbols—a flaming torch and a man blowing a turha, respectively—and the opposite of a head start.

Given the state of impasse over the seat, Congress leaders have called for a "friendly fight" in Sangli and other constituencies like Mumbai South Central and Bhiwandi, which, too, the Sena (UBT) and NCP (Sharad Pawar) are claiming in the coming elections despite being seats the Congress has contested in the past. This means the allies will be free to nominate their respective candidates for these seats, instead of one face representing the alliance. "We want to fight from Sangli and win. The issue will be discussed in a meeting of the MVA. If it is not resolved, we have the option of going in for a friendly fight," says a Congress leader speaking on condition of anonymity.

However, senior leaders in both the Congress and Sena (UBT) warn that "friendly fights" could create a wrong picture of the alliance, eroding voter sympathy, and thus be injurious to the interests of both parties. Speaking on the issue, Shiv Sena (UBT) Rajya Sabha MP Sanjay Raut said: "The Congress is a large party. We want the Congress to lead the country... we want the prime minister to be from the Congress. Are they going to lose the prime ministership over the Sangli seat?"

Also, as Harshal Pradhan, the party's spokesperson, reminded everyone, "The Congress could get just one MP elected to the Lok Sabha in 2019 [from Maharashtra] while our tally was 18. This angle must also be considered." But then all is fair in love and politics, reason be damned. ■

EXODUS HITS CONGRESS

Scores of Congress leaders and workers shift allegiance to the BJP, raising questions about the Grand Old Party's winnability, unity and leadership stability

By Rahul Noronha

Former state home minister Narottam Mishra now does duty as the convenor of the local BJP joining cell. It's a job that keeps him incredibly busy these days. On March 29, Kamlesh Shah, a three-term Congress MLA from Amarwara, drove up to Chief Minister Mohan Yadav's residence in Bhopal and joined the BJP along with other members of his family, including wife Madhvi Shah, the president of the Harrai nagar panchayat in Chhindwara district. The welcome party included the CM, state BJP president V.D. Sharma and Mishra himself, who uttered a line that he could probably say in his sleep by now: that Shah had been "inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's leadership". Three days later, Chhindwara mayor Vikram Ahake, the state's youngest and first tribal mayor and a key loyalist of senior Congress leader Kamal Nath, also switched to the BJP camp. He claimed he was upset about MP Nakul Nath's remarks about tribals.

In what has become almost a daily feature across the state, Congress leaders of varying vintage have been joining the BJP in droves. The process began weeks after the assembly election verdict came out in December. Shah and Ahake's defections hold special significance given that they were Kamal Nath's closest associates. The Chhindwara

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BJP Vs BJP

The party faces dissent in at least six seats. Reasons range from nomination of outsiders to non-performance

By Jumana Shah

The adage that 'dissent is the highest form of patriotism' appears to be hitting home for the BJP in Gujarat. Having held unchallenged political dominance in the state for nearly three decades, the party is now faced with rebellion in at least six of the 26 Lok Sabha constituencies. One of the main reasons for the dissent is the influx of several Congress leaders and their followers into the BJP, allegedly at the expense of party old-timers.

A fortnight ago, dissidence erupted in the Sabarkantha and Vadodara constituencies. Bhikaji Thakor, a former VHP leader of 25 years, was initially chosen as the Sabarkantha candidate, but he withdrew within a week, citing personal reasons. One reason doing the rounds was the Opposition's charge that he had changed his surname to Thakor (OBC) for political gains—it had been Damor (tribal) till 2018. As the BJP fielded Shobhana Baraiya, wife of former Congress leader Mahendrasinh Baraiya who had joined the BJP in